

God's Covenant With Noah and All Creation: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:8-17

8 **And Elohim said to Noah** and to his sons **with him**, saying,

9 "And I myself, behold, **I set up my covenant** **with y'all**,
and with your seed after you;

10 and **with every living creature** that is **with you**,
the birds, the beasts, and every **living creature** of the land **with you**;
from everything that comes out of the ark,
even every **living creature** of the land.

11 And **I set up my covenant with y'all**;
and never again will **all flesh** **be cut off by the waters of the flood**,
and never again will there be a flood to ruin the land."

12 **And Elohim said**,

"This is **the sign of the covenant** which I am giving
between me and between you
and between every living creature that is **with you**, for everlasting generations;

13 I give **my bow in the cloud**,
and it will be for **a sign of a covenant**
between me and between the land;

14 and it will come about when **I cloud a cloud** over the land,
that **it will be seen**, **the bow in the cloud**,

15 and **I will remember** **my covenant**,
which is **between me and between you**
and between every living creature of all flesh;
and never again will the waters become a flood to ruin all flesh.

16 And **the bow is in the cloud**,
then **I will see it**,
to remember **the everlasting covenant**
between Elohim and between every living creature,
with all flesh that is on the land."

17 **And Elohim said to Noah**,

“This is **the sign of the covenant which I have set up**
between me and all flesh that is on the land.”

Genesis 9:8-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This is the first formal covenant speech and ceremony in the Hebrew Bible. It sets the design pattern for all future covenants that God makes with Abraham (Gen. 15; Gen. 17), the Israelites (Exod. 19-24), Phineas (Num. 25), and David (2 Sam. 7). It also sets the terms for the prophetic hope of the new covenant (Ezek. 36; Jer. 31; Isa. 54-55).

Literary Design and Main Theme

Gordon Wenham points out in his book *Genesis 1-15* that God’s covenant speech is designed in three movements, and the first and last movements form an introductory and concluding frame around the substance of the speech in the center (Wenham, 1987).

The covenant between God and all creation, mankind, and the animals is confirmed by God putting the rainbow in the clouds and making three speeches in verses 9-11, 12-16, 17. These are arranged concentrically.

A 9:9–11	“And I will establish (הקמתי) my covenant with you and your seed ... and all living creatures”			
	B 9:12a	And God said, “This is sign (אות) of the covenant”		
		C 9:12b	my covenant “for eternal (עולם) generations”	
			D 9:13–16	“my bow (קשתי) which I place in the cloud, it will be for a sign (אות) of the covenant between me and all the land”
		C’ 9:16	I will remember “eternal (עולם) covenant”	
	B’ 9:17a	And God said to Noah, “This is the sign (אות) of my covenant”		
A’ 9:17b	“the covenant which I am establishing (הקמתי) between me and all flesh”			

Chiasm of Genesis 9:9-17. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

“The first speech, vv 9-11, introduces the topic of the covenant and its content, the future stability of the cosmos. The second and most important speech, vv 12-16, equates the confirmation of the covenant with setting the rainbow in the clouds. The sign of the covenant is its confirmation. The third and final speech, v 17, sums up the significance of the whole event.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15](#). Thomas Nelson. 172-173.

Notice that the word “covenant” appears seven times.

The Cosmic Covenant

This is the first covenant speech and ceremony in the Hebrew Bible, and it appears after Noah’s sacrifice. Noah’s sacrifice is the narrative embodiment of his obedience that releases God’s blessing into a new creation and qualifies him to intercede on behalf of creation. It is fitting, therefore, that God makes a covenant with all creation (“cosmic covenant”) through a covenant with Noah.

Covenant (Heb. *berit* / ברית)

“A solemn commitment of oneself to undertake an obligation.”

Waltke, Bruce K. (2001). [Genesis: A Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 287.

“A covenant is an enduring agreement which defines a relationship between two parties involving a solemn, binding obligation on one or both parties, made by oath under threat of divine curse, and ratified by a visual ritual.”

Adapted from Lane, C. Daniel (2000). “*The Meaning and Use of the Old Testament Term for ‘Covenant’ (berît): with Some Implications for Dispensationalism and Covenant Theology*.” PhD diss., Trinity International University. 314.

A covenant is the formalization of a partnership between two parties so that they can accomplish or work toward a common end to each other’s benefit. The word “covenant” occurs 284 times in biblical Hebrew, clustered around certain covenant-making narratives or in texts that reference those narratives.

Covenants Between People in the Hebrew Bible

Covenant Type	Examples
International treaties	• King Solomon and King Hiram make a peace treaty and promise to share economic abundance for each other’s benefit (1 Kgs. 5:12). • Joshua and the Gibeonites make a peace treaty that exempts the Gibeonites from attack during the Israelite conquest of the land (Josh. 9:6-7, 11, 15-16).
Covenants Between People in the Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenant Type	Examples
Clan/tribal alliances	• The neighboring clans of Abraham and Mamre promise to protect each other (Gen. 14:13). • Abraham and Abimelek promise to interact with integrity after Abraham's deception regarding Sarah (Gen. 21:27, 32). • Isaac and Abimelek promise to benefit one another and do no harm (Gen. 26:28).
Personal agreements	• Jacob and Laban (Gen. 31:44) promise not to cross the Israel/Aram border to do harm.
Loyalty agreements	• Jonathan promises to protect David from his father Saul and swears loyalty to David (1 Sam. 18:3, 20:8, 23:18). • The northern tribes of Israel promise to acknowledge the Judean David as their tribal king (2 Sam. 5:3).
Marriage	• Marriage is a loyalty agreement between a man and woman (see Prov. 2:17 and Mal. 2:14).
<i>Covenants Between People in the Bible.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenants Between God and People in the Hebrew Bible

Covenant	Reference
Creation covenant	?
Covenant with Noah and all creation	Genesis 6:18, 9:8-17
Covenant with Abraham	Genesis 12, 15, 17, 22:15-18
Covenant with Israel	Exodus 19-24; Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28
Covenant with Levi	Numbers 25:6-13; Malachi 2:1-9
Covenant with David	2 Samuel 7; Psalm 89, 132
<i>Covenants Between God and People.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Covenant	Reference
The New Covenant	Jeremiah 31; Ezekiel 36
<i>Covenants Between God and People</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

“With the Noahic covenant promising the stability of the cosmic structure, the Abrahamic covenant promising people and land, the Davidic covenant promising sovereignty, and the Israelite covenant promising life, security, and prosperity, the biblical authors and editors possessed a platform from which they could portray and reconcile nearly every historical tradition, legendary, didactic, and folk account in their tradition. If we deleted all references to covenant ... we would have simply an anthology of stories. As it is, we have a structure that can house a macro-plot.”

Friedman, Richard Elliot (1987). “The Hiding of the Face: An Essay on the Literary Unity of Biblical Narrative.” Neusner, J. (Ed.) [*Judaic Perspectives on Ancient Israel*](#). Fortress Press. 215.

In every one of these covenants, God forwards his purpose to provide a seed of the woman who will restore the Eden blessing to humanity and creation. Each covenant narrows down the lineage of promise as each generation passes and/or fails the test of faithfulness to God’s purposes.

A Covenant in Eden?

Given that all post-Eden covenants include allusions back to Genesis 1-2, many traditions believe that there was a covenant in place between God and Adam and Eve that was (a) unspoken and (b) broken in Genesis 3.

The absence of the word “covenant” in Genesis 1 or 2 is conspicuous. Why isn’t the relationship between God and Adam and Eve described as a covenant? A handful of reasons suggest themselves.

If Genesis 1-2 represents a divine-human ideal, then it seems important that while it’s not called a covenant, it is described with the basic elements of a covenant. Humans are God’s royal priestly representatives (the image of God), and they are invited to trust and follow God’s command (Gen. 2:15-17). If they do, there will be eternal life, and if not, death will result.

It is only after this primordial relationship between God and humans has been violated that God begins to initiate a succession of covenants.

“Covenants served to ... offer assurances, bolster faith, and reinforce commitments. In a world not invaded by sin, there would be no need for adding oaths to commitments, no need for ‘covenants’—no more than in such a world would oaths be necessary to establish the truth of one’s ‘yes’ or ‘no’ (see [Matt. 5:34-37](#); [Jas. 5:12](#); [Heb. 6:16](#)). Biblical covenants were emergency measures occasioned by and ministering to human weakness—until the kingdom of God has fully come.”

Stek, John (1994). “‘Covenant’ Overload in Reformed Theology.” *Calvin Theological Journal* Volume 29 (1). 40.